

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 40

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: A retired postman walks his old delivery route through a quiet neighbourhood and reflects on a working life spent among strangers.

1

On the first cool morning of October, with nothing pressing me into a uniform any longer, I laced up my old walking shoes and set off down Eastfield Road for the simple pleasure of doing again what I had done five mornings a week for thirty-one years. The bag on my shoulder was empty, of course, and lighter for it, but my hand kept reaching for letters that were no longer there. Habit, it seems, has a longer memory than the body.

2

I had known the road first by its dogs. Number four was a black-and-white spaniel called Pip, who barked at everything that moved except, mysteriously, me. Number twelve was the place of two cats — both ginger, both named Henry by a woman who saw no reason to invent a second name. Number nineteen was the Bensons' Labrador, who waited each morning by the gate with the patient expectancy of a small dignitary about to receive an envoy. Pip had been gone for nine years now. The Labrador, I was almost sure, had outlived the Bensons themselves.

3

The houses had changed, but only in the small, sideways way that houses do. A hedge that had once half-swallowed the postbox at number twenty-three had been pulled out, root and all, and replaced by a low brick wall the colour of weak tea. The gate at number thirty-one, which had squealed at me every morning for a decade and then, one famous winter, simply fallen off in my hand, was now a smart aluminium thing that swung in silence. A house I had once known by its peeling green door — number forty-five, the violin teacher — had been painted, kindly enough, a respectful charcoal. The street remembered me, I thought; it had simply been redecorated in my absence.

4

Two streets in, an old woman at number sixty-eight straightened up from her roses and looked at me with

the slow, careful attention of someone retrieving a name from deep storage. “Mr Aldridge,” she said at last, half a question. I had not been Mr Aldridge to anyone for two years. I had been, in retirement, just Tom — to a wife, to a few neighbours, to the man at the post office counter who now sorted, with crisper fingers than mine, the bundles I used to carry. To be Mr Aldridge again, on this familiar pavement, was like putting on a coat I had thought was given away.

5

“You used to bring our letters,” she said. I admitted that I had. She told me, then, about the Christmas card from her grandson in Aberdeen that had arrived, year after year, only because I had once knocked on her door to ask whether she would prefer it left under the mat or behind the milk bottle when she was out. She remembered. I, in honest truth, did not. There must have been four hundred such small arrangements made along this road over the years, and to me they had been only the daily business of getting paper from one hand into another.

6

I walked on, more slowly now. The strange grace of the morning was beginning to find me. For three decades I had been a thin, daily thread running between houses that did not know each other, carrying birthday cards from cousins, letters from banks, brown envelopes that made people sigh, occasional thin blue airmail sheets that made them sit down on the stairs. I had been, in a small and entirely unromantic way, useful — useful to strangers who would not, by and large, have recognised me out of uniform. And the strangers, it seemed, had quietly held the memory for me until I came back to collect it.

7

At the end of the road I stopped at the bench by the bus stop, which had been new when I retired and was now scuffed and properly worn in. I sat down. A small boy on a scooter went past, ringing a bell at nothing in particular, and an old man at the corner shop lifted a hand in vague greeting, perhaps to me, perhaps to the day itself. I thought of all the doors I had once approached without thinking, and of the lives that had gone on, polite and unremarkable, behind each of them.

8

On the walk home I took the long way round, past the school and the war memorial and the bakery that had changed hands three times during my service and was now, apparently, called Olive. The bag on my shoulder felt, for the first time, properly empty — not the emptiness of having delivered everything, but the gentler emptiness of having nothing left to deliver. I would, I decided, come this way again next week. A man, after all, ought to remain on speaking terms with the streets that have known him.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says that “habit... has a longer memory than the body.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase suggests about the narrator’s first morning of retirement. [2]

From Paragraph 2

2. The narrator says he “had known the road first by its dogs.” What does this tell us about how he came to understand the neighbourhood during his working life? [2]

3. Give **one** detail from Paragraph 2 that suggests a considerable amount of time has passed since the narrator’s working days. [1]

From Paragraph 3

4. The narrator says the street “had simply been redecorated in my absence.” What does this phrase suggest about how he feels about the changes to the road? Support your answer with **one** detail from Paragraph 3. [2]

From Paragraph 4

5. The old woman looks at the narrator “with the slow, careful attention of someone retrieving a name from deep storage.”

- (a) What does this description tell us about the old woman? [1]
(b) Why is it significant that she calls him “Mr Aldridge”? [1]

From Paragraph 5

6. The narrator describes the postal arrangements as “the daily business of getting paper from one hand into another.” Explain how the language used in Paragraph 5 makes the narrator’s old job seem ordinary to him, even though it was clearly important to the woman. Support your answer with **two** details from Paragraph 5. [3]

From Paragraph 6

7. The narrator describes himself as “a thin, daily thread running between houses that did not know each other.” Explain what this image suggests about his role in the neighbourhood. [2]

8. The narrator says he was “useful — useful to strangers”. What does the **repetition** of the word “useful” suggest about how he now views his old work? [1]

From Paragraph 7

9. Give **one** piece of evidence from Paragraph 7 that suggests the narrator is in a thoughtful, reflective mood. [1]

From Paragraph 8

10. The narrator distinguishes between the emptiness “of having delivered everything” and “the gentler emptiness of having nothing left to deliver.” Explain, in your own words, the difference between the two. [2]

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article on the rapid rise — and growing risks — of facial-recognition technology in public life.

1

A decade ago, the idea that a camera might recognise your face from across a crowded concourse belonged firmly to the world of spy thrillers. Today it is, in many countries, a routine fact of public life. Travellers in Singapore, Dubai and Atlanta pass through airport gates that match their faces to passport photographs in less than two seconds. Retailers in London and Sydney quietly scan their shop floors for known thieves. Police forces from Buenos Aires to Beijing run live cameras against watchlists. The technology has spread with a speed that few regulators anticipated and that fewer still have managed to contain.

2

The benefits, in fairness, are not imaginary. Facial-recognition systems have been used to reunite missing children with their families, sometimes after years of separation; one Indian programme, deployed in 2018, reportedly identified almost three thousand children in a single trial run. Airports report shorter queues and lower staffing costs. Police investigators, faced with grainy footage of a serious crime, have traced suspects in hours rather than weeks. Even ordinary citizens benefit in small ways: phones unlock on a glance, banking apps confirm identity without a password, and entry to one's own apartment becomes a matter of walking up to the door. To dismiss the technology outright would be to ignore the genuine convenience and safety it has brought.

3

The trouble is that the same systems are nowhere near as accurate as their marketing suggests, and they fail in ways that are far from random. A widely cited 2019 study by the United States National Institute of Standards and Technology tested nearly two hundred commercial algorithms and found that most produced significantly higher error rates for women than for men, and for darker-skinned faces than for lighter ones — in some cases by a factor of ten or more. The consequences have not been theoretical. Several men in the United States have been wrongfully arrested after being misidentified by police software; all of them, so far, have been Black. A system that fails unevenly is not merely a flawed tool. It is a tool that distributes its failures along the lines of existing prejudice.

4

There is also the problem of consent. A traveller who walks through an airport gate has, in some loose sense, agreed to be scanned; the gate is a choice. A pedestrian crossing a public square, however, has not chosen anything. She has simply gone outside. When her face is captured, matched against a database, and logged with a timestamp, she is taking part in a transaction she did not know was taking place, with a partner she cannot see, on terms she has not read. Privacy, the philosopher Helen Nissbaum has argued, depends not only on whether one is observed, but on whether the observation is appropriate to the context. Most public surveillance, on that measure, fails badly.

5

Regulators have responded in strikingly different ways. The European Union's Artificial Intelligence Act, which came into force in 2024, bans most live facial recognition in public spaces, treating it as a fundamental threat to civil liberty. Several American cities — San Francisco, Boston, Portland — have prohibited its use by their own police forces. China, meanwhile, has built a national network estimated to comprise more than half a billion cameras, integrated explicitly with social-credit systems. Singapore has taken a middle path, deploying the technology selectively, with parliamentary scrutiny and published guidelines. The world, in short, is conducting an enormous unplanned experiment, with little agreement on what counts as success.

6

Defenders of the technology often argue that those who have done nothing wrong have nothing to fear. The argument is older than the cameras, and just as misleading. Privacy is not only the refuge of the guilty; it is also the condition under which ordinary citizens form opinions, attend protests, visit clinics, see lawyers, and otherwise exercise the freedoms that make a society democratic. A society in which every face in every street is logged is not a society of innocents. It is a society of suspects waiting to be cleared. Whether that is the kind of public space any of us wants is a question that has been asked, so far, mostly by people who have already lost it.

7

What facial recognition forces us to reconsider, in the end, is the very meaning of privacy in public. For most of human history, anonymity in a crowd was a basic given. One could walk down a street without being known, recorded, or named, unless one chose otherwise. That assumption, quietly and almost without debate, is being dismantled. Whether it should be — and on whose terms, with what safeguards, and at what cost — is now among the most urgent questions of the decade. The technology will not pause while we work out the answer. But neither, fortunately, are we yet obliged to accept whatever it offers us simply because it is offered.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says that, a decade ago, facial recognition “belonged firmly to the world of spy thrillers.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase suggests about how the technology was once viewed. [2]

From Paragraph 2

13. According to Paragraph 2, give **two** benefits of facial-recognition technology to ordinary citizens (as opposed to police or airports). [2]

14. The writer says, “To dismiss the technology outright would be to ignore the genuine convenience and safety it has brought.” What is the writer’s **purpose** in including this sentence? [2]

From Paragraph 3

15. The writer says the systems “fail in ways that are far from random.” Explain, in your own words, what this means. [2]

16. Give **one** piece of evidence from Paragraph 3 that shows the failures of facial-recognition systems have real-world consequences. [1]

From Paragraph 4

17. Explain, in your own words, the difference the writer draws between a traveller in an airport and a pedestrian in a public square. [2]

18. What is the **effect** of the writer’s phrase “with a partner she cannot see, on terms she has not read”? [2]

From Paragraph 5

19. The writer says the world is “conducting an enormous unplanned experiment.” Give **two** details from Paragraph 5 that support this description. [2]

From Paragraph 6

20. The writer says a society watched in this way “is not a society of innocents. It is a society of suspects waiting to be cleared.” Explain what is **effective** about this contrast. [2]

From Paragraph 7

21. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **the problems with facial-recognition technology** and **how different regulators have responded to it**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 3 to 5** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

One major problem with facial-recognition technology is that ...

— END OF PAPER —